

FREE GUIDE · MAKE COLLEGE PAY OFF

The College ROI *Starter Kit*

The 25 places students forget to look for scholarships, grants, internships, fellowships & funded opportunities.

Naomi Peters

MORE OPPORTUNITY. LESS DEBT.



20+

SCHOLARSHIPS

5

GRANTS

30+

COUNTRIES

\$0

STUDENT DEBT

The money is out there. *It's just not where most students look.*



Most students search the same two or three scholarship websites and stop there.

The money, jobs and programs that are easiest to win are usually somewhere else: in your own department, your hometown, your parents' workplaces and offices on campus you've never visited.

I didn't receive need-based aid, and my family didn't pay my tuition. I graduated with a finance degree, 20+ scholarships, 5 grants and \$0 in student debt (after starting late). This guide is the list I wish I'd had on day one.

— *Naomi*

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

1

Read one section at a time. There are five, with five places in each.

2

For every place, write down one specific thing to look up this week.

3

Put every deadline you find into the opportunity calendar at the end.

My results are my own and every student's situation is different. Eligibility, amounts and deadlines change every year, so always confirm details with the source.

01 Scholarships beyond the big search engines

Local and niche scholarships get far fewer applicants than national ones, so your odds per application are much better.

1 Your own department's scholarships

Many departments award money separately from the main financial aid office, often to just a handful of students in the major.

HOW TO FIND IT Email your department administrator: "What scholarships does our department award, and when do applications open?"

2 Your parents' or guardians' employers

Many companies, unions and credit unions offer scholarships to employees' children.

HOW TO FIND IT Ask each parent or guardian to check their HR or benefits portal, and search "[employer name] scholarship."

3 Your local community foundation

Most counties and cities have a community foundation that runs dozens of small scholarships through one application.

HOW TO FIND IT Search "[your county or city] community foundation scholarships."

4 Civic and service clubs

Rotary, Lions, Kiwanis, Elks and similar clubs often fund scholarships through their local chapters.

HOW TO FIND IT Check the websites of the chapters in your hometown and your college town, or call and ask.

5 Professional associations in your field

Groups for accountants, engineers, nurses, journalists and most other careers have student scholarships, and student membership is often cheap or free.

HOW TO FIND IT Search "[your field] association student scholarship."

02

PLACES 6-10

Grants and department awards

Grants are money you don't repay, and many are awarded by offices that never advertise beyond campus.

6

The FAFSA, every year

Federal and state grants start here, and many colleges also require it for their own merit awards. File it every year even if you think you won't qualify.

HOW TO FIND IT studentaid.gov, plus your state's higher-education agency for state grants.

7

Undergraduate research funding

Many schools pay students stipends to do research with faculty, especially over the summer.

HOW TO FIND IT Look for an "Office of Undergraduate Research" on your college's website, or ask a professor whose work interests you.

8

Conference and travel grants

Departments, honors programs and the conferences themselves often cover registration, travel or lodging for students.

HOW TO FIND IT Ask your department before you register, and look for "student scholarship" or "travel grant" on the conference website.

9

Student government and honors program funds

Many have budgets for student projects, events and professional development.

HOW TO FIND IT Search your college's site for "student project funding," or ask your honors office.

10

Dean of students and emergency funds

Many colleges keep small grants for unexpected costs like books, travel home or a gap in aid.

HOW TO FIND IT Search "[your college] emergency grant," or ask the dean of students' office directly.

03

PLACES 11–15

Internships and co-ops

Paid experience is both income and career capital, and the best roles are often filled before they're ever posted publicly.

11

Your career center's job board

Employers post here specifically because they want students from your school, so competition is smaller than on national sites.

HOW TO FIND IT Log in to your college's job board (many schools use Handshake) and set alerts for your field.

12

Co-op programs

Co-ops are paid, full-time roles that usually last a semester or longer, often at large companies. They pay more than most internships and frequently lead to job offers.

HOW TO FIND IT Search "[company] co-op program," and ask your career center which employers recruit co-ops from your school.

13

Your college's alumni

Alumni are often glad to help students from their own school.

HOW TO FIND IT On LinkedIn, open your college's page and click Alumni to filter by company, city and field. Ask for a 15-minute conversation, not a job.

14

Faculty and research labs

Professors hire students as paid research assistants and rarely advertise widely.

HOW TO FIND IT Read faculty pages in your department and email two or three whose work interests you, saying what you'd like to learn.

15

Startups, small businesses and nonprofits

Smaller organizations often give students real responsibility sooner.

HOW TO FIND IT Look at your city's startup or entrepreneurship network, chamber of commerce and nonprofit job boards.

04 PLACES 16-20 Fellowships and funded programs

Fellowships pay you to learn, research or lead, and many students never apply simply because they never hear about them.

16 Your college's fellowships office

Many colleges have an office that helps students apply for nationally competitive awards, and some programs require your college to nominate you.

HOW TO FIND IT Search “[your college] fellowships office” and meet an advisor early, often a year before deadlines.

17 Summer research programs (REUs)

The National Science Foundation funds Research Experiences for Undergraduates: paid summer research programs at universities across the country.

HOW TO FIND IT Search “NSF REU sites” and filter by your field.

18 National scholarships with a mission

Programs such as the Goldwater (research careers in science, math and engineering), Truman (public service) and Udall (environment, and tribal policy or health care) fund students who show early commitment to a field.

HOW TO FIND IT Read each program's eligibility page, then talk with your fellowships office about whether you're a fit.

19 Leadership summits and conferences

Many offer free or discounted student registration, and some cover travel. Being in the room is how you meet people who hire and fund.

HOW TO FIND IT Search “[your field or interest] conference student scholarship” and check each event's registration page.

20 Cause-based nonprofits and foundations

Organizations focused on a cause you care about, like community service, interfaith work, health or the environment, often run their own student fellowships.

HOW TO FIND IT Search “[your cause] student fellowship,” and look at the programs page of organizations you already follow.

05

PLACES 21-25

Study-abroad and international funding

Studying abroad can cost less than students assume, but most funding has deadlines months before the program starts.

21

Your study abroad office

Many colleges offer their own study abroad scholarships, and exchange agreements sometimes let you pay your home tuition while studying abroad.

HOW TO FIND IT Ask a study abroad advisor: "Which programs cost about the same as a semester here, and what funding do you offer?"

22

The Gilman Scholarship

A U.S. Department of State program for students receiving Federal Pell Grants, to help fund study or internships abroad.

HOW TO FIND IT Search "Gilman Scholarship" and check the current eligibility and deadlines.

23

Boren Awards and the Critical Language Scholarship

Both fund the study of languages the U.S. government considers critical. CLS runs funded summer language institutes; Boren includes a federal service requirement afterward.

HOW TO FIND IT Search each by name and talk to your fellowships office.

24

Study abroad program providers

Organizations that run study abroad programs, such as CIEE, IES Abroad and API, offer their own scholarships and grants.

HOW TO FIND IT Once you've picked a program, look for "scholarships" on its provider's website.

25

The Fund for Education Abroad, and Fulbright after graduation

FEA offers scholarships focused on students underrepresented in study abroad. For seniors and recent graduates, the Fulbright U.S. Student Program funds a year of study, research or teaching abroad.

HOW TO FIND IT Search each by name. Fulbright applications are usually due in the fall of senior year.

Build your *opportunity calendar*

Most opportunities open on a predictable yearly cycle. Typical timing is below; your own deadlines will vary.

FALL · SEP-NOV

Apply early

FAFSA for next year; large-company summer internships and co-ops; national fellowships and Fulbright.

Do now: file the FAFSA early, apply to internships, meet your fellowships office.

WINTER · DEC-FEB

Line up summer

Summer research programs (REUs), more summer internships, and many study abroad applications.

Do now: ask professors for recommendations at least 3–4 weeks ahead.

SPRING · MAR-MAY

Go local

Local, community foundation and club scholarships, plus department awards for next year.

Do now: check every department and local deadline; reuse and tailor your essays.

SUMMER · JUN-AUG

Get ready

Few deadlines, which makes it the best time to prepare.

Do now: update your resume, draft core essays, list next year's deadlines.

MY OPPORTUNITY TRACKER

OPPORTUNITY	WHERE I FOUND IT	DEADLINE	AMOUNT / PAY	STATUS

YOUR NEXT STEP

Pick three places. *Look them up this week.*

Scholarships are only one piece of the puzzle. Your college strategy should connect money, opportunities, experience and what comes next.

If you'd like help deciding where to focus, book a free 20-minute College ROI Call. We'll find your biggest bottleneck and the opportunities you may be missing.

[BOOK YOUR FREE 20-MINUTE CALL →](#)

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COLLEGE MONEY, OPPORTUNITY & CAREER STRATEGY

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